a piece of carrot or *gud* (jaggery) in our pockets as a treat for the horse. If the horse had not behaved properly, thrown us off or bucked, or not gone into an obliging canter, we would eat that treat ourselves! No matter that it would be a soggy stinking mess after an hour in the pocket of our breeches. Kids will be kids.

My mother was a teacher, to begin with, and had taught in the Scindia Kanya Vidyalaya, Gwalior, during our stay there. She was a BA and BEd, which was a high qualification for women in those days. This teaching career, of course, went for a six once we went to France. She was also a short-story writer of repute. She wrote in Marathi, and her stories were most sought-after by various Marathi magazines, particularly for their Diwali Special issue. Her stories revolved around real-life experiences, many based on incidents in France, and always had a human element to them. Oftentimes, something that we told her, an incident in school or a closely fought match, would wend its way into her stories. Whenever that happened, we were quick to catch on to the person or incident on which that story was based. It was a game between us; she would narrate the story and we would try to guess the person, incident or outcome.

Towards the latter part of our stay in Delhi, my mother applied for and got selected as a translator-cum-news reader, in the Marathi division of All India Radio. This involved taking the English language news feeds, translating them by hand and then going 'on air' to read the news live. It was quite a stressful job. All the people on duty for that bulletin had to report about three hours in advance, do the translation against the clock and then be composed enough to read the news faultlessly in one go. There were three such bulletins each day and two duties a day was the norm. Back-to-back duties—morning and afternoon

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